

retirement.

Economic life should be definancialized. We should learn not to use markets as warehouses of value: they do not harbor the certainties that normal citizens can require, in spite of “expert” opinions. Investments should be for entertainment. Citizens should experience anxiety from their own businesses (which they control), not from their investments (which they do not control).

10. Make an omelet with the broken eggs.

Finally, the crisis of 2008 was not a problem to fix with makeshift repairs, any more than a boat with a rotten hull can be fixed with ad hoc patches. We need to rebuild the new hull with new (stronger) material; we will have to remake the system before it does so itself. Let us move voluntarily into a robust economy by helping what needs to be broken break on its own, converting debt into equity, marginalizing the economics and business school establishments, shutting down the “Nobel” in economics, banning leveraged buyouts, putting bankers where they belong, clawing back the bonuses of those who got us here (by claiming restitution of the funds paid to, say, Robert Rubin or bankers whose wealth has been subsidized by taxpaying schoolteachers), and teaching people to navigate a world with fewer certainties.

Then we will see an economic life closer to our biological environment: smaller firms, a richer ecology, no speculative leverage—a world in which entrepreneurs, not bankers, take the risks, and in which companies are born and die every day without making the news.

After this foray into business economics, let us now move to something less vulgar.

* This passage was published as an editorial in 2009 in the *Financial Times*. Some editor—who no doubt had not read *The Black Swan*—changed my “Black-Swan-robust” into “Black-Swan-proof.” There is no such thing as Black Swan proof, but robust is good enough.